



Survey Methods

1.2 – Surveys in health research

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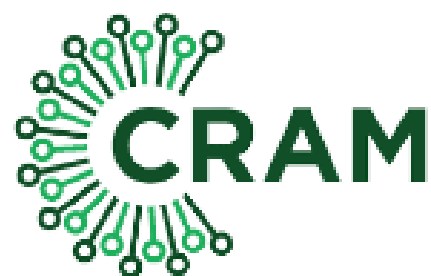
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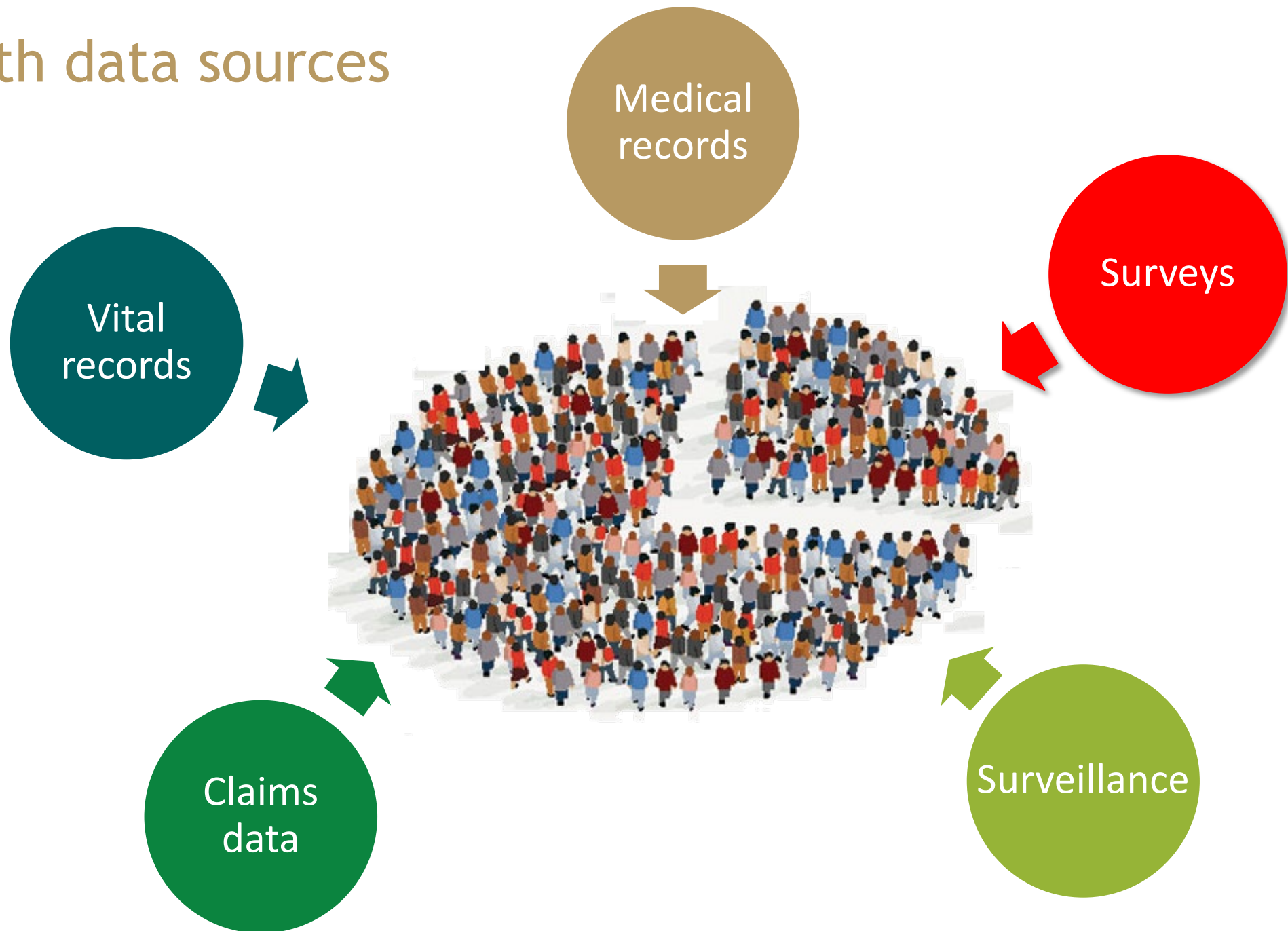
Outline

- Why survey in health research?
- Types of surveys
- Alternative designs
- Some examples

Why survey in health research?



Health data sources



Strengths & weaknesses



- Cost-effectiveness
- Generalizability
- Reliability
- Versatility



- Inflexibility
- Lack of depth

weaknesses (cont)

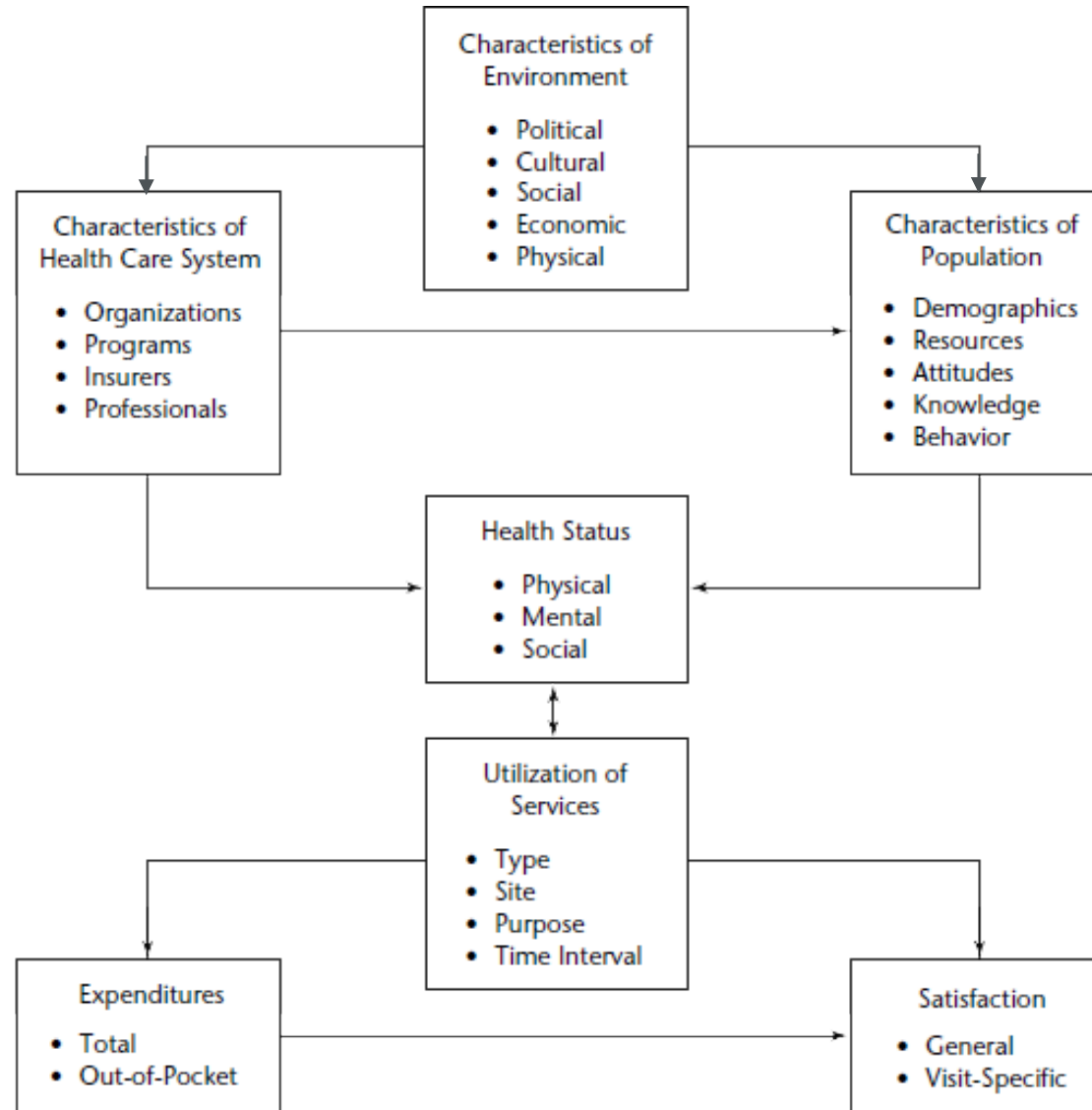
- hard to get detailed information;
- people can refuse to participate (low response rates);
- people can choose not to answer/provide correct answer questions about socially undesirable behaviours;
- people cannot remember important details correctly or at all (recall bias);
- low response rates,
- exclusions of part of the target population (e.g. homeless people may be excluded from a survey conducted via mail; people without health insurance who cannot afford to see a doctor may be excluded from surveys conducted by health care providers).

Health surveys

Health surveys serve as a critical resource to measure the health status, risk factors, and health behaviours of the population and to assess the level of quality of the health care received. They also permit the identification of disparities in health care associated with access, use, cost, and insurance coverage and serve to identify related patterns and trends over time. The descriptive and analytical findings they generate are key inputs to facilitate the development, implementation, and evaluation of policies and practices addressing health and health care..

(Aday and Cornelius 2006:xi)

A classification of health surveys topics



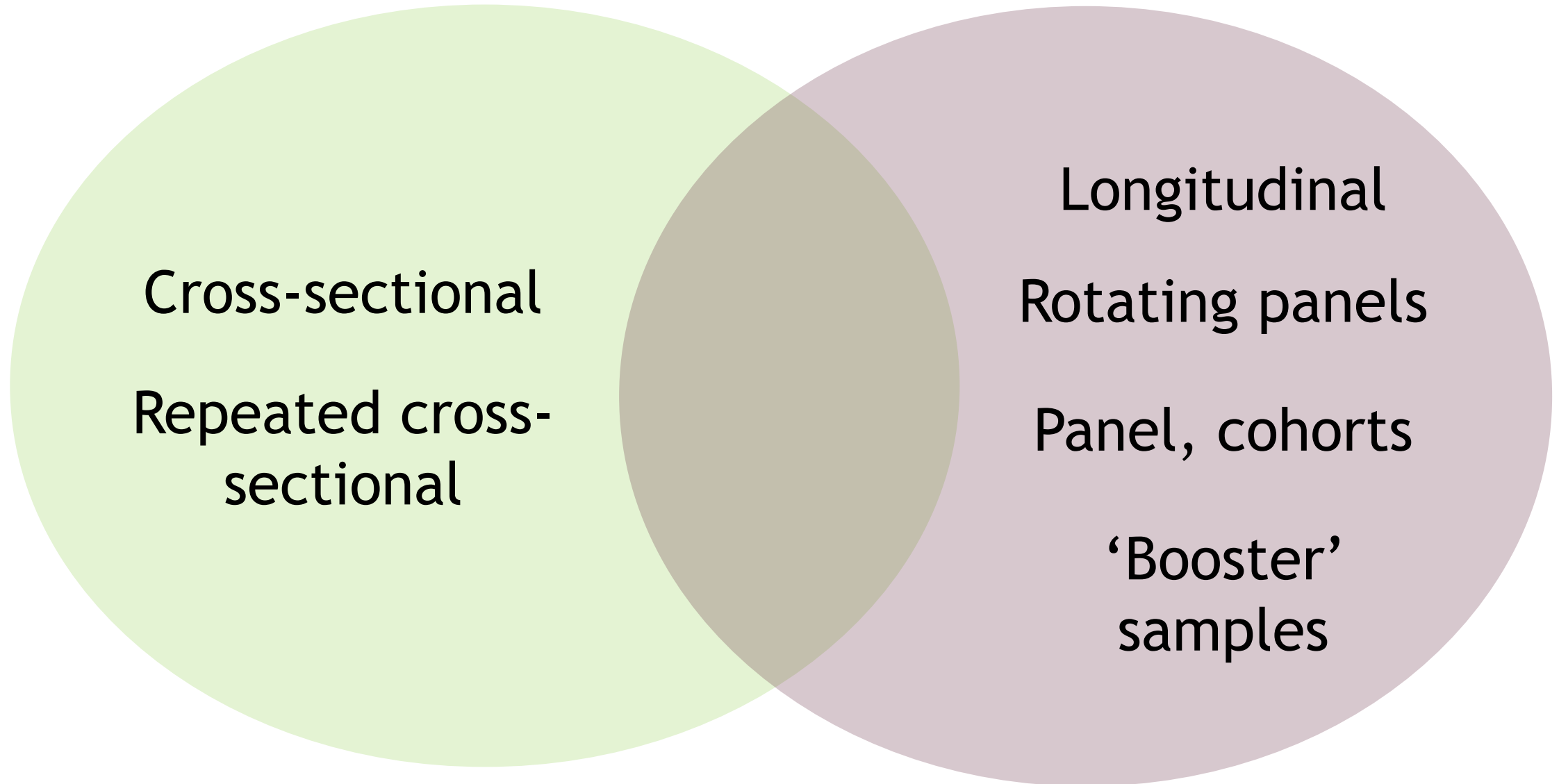
(Adapted from Aday and Cornelius 2006:13)

Research question(s) and study designs

Observational

Elements of Research Question	Descriptive			Analytical			Experimental
	Cross-Sectional	Group-Comparison	Longitudinal	Cross-Sectional	Case-Control	Prospective	
What?	What is the <i>prevalence</i> of cigarette smokers	Do the characteristics of those who are cigarette smokers and those who are not <i>differ</i>	What is the <i>incidence</i> of cigarette smokers	Are cigarette smokers <i>more likely</i> than nonsmokers	Are cigarette smokers <i>more likely</i> than nonsmokers	Is the <i>incidence</i> of cigarette smokers <i>greater</i>	Is the <i>incidence</i> of cigarette smokers <i>less</i>
Who?	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors
Where?	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school
When?	in the last month of school?	in the last month of school?	between the first and the last month of school?	in the last month of school	in the last month of school	between the first and the last month of school	between the first and the last month of school
Why?	—	—	—	to have friends who smoke?	to have friends who have a history of smoking?	for those whose friends start to smoke?	for those randomly assigned to a teen peer antismoking program?

Cross-sectional, longitudinal, mixed



Research question(s) and study designs

Elements of Research Question	Descriptive		Observational		Analytical		Experimental
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Who?	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors	among seniors
Where?	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school	of a large urban high school
When?	in the last month of school?	in the last month of school?	between the first and the last month of school?	in the last month of school	in the last month of school	between the first and the last month of school	between the first and the last month of school
Why?	—	—	—	to have friends who smoke?	to have friends who have a history of smoking?	for those whose friends start to smoke?	for those randomly assigned to a teen peer antismoking program?



Small

Medium

Large

Extra Large

Some examples

Hird TR et al. (2016) Burden of Diabetes and First Evidence for the Utility of HbA1c for Diagnosis and Detection of Diabetes in Urban Black South Africans: The Durban Diabetes Study. PLoS ONE 11(8):e0161966. doi:[10.1371/journal.pone.0161966](https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0161966)

Hodkinson PW et Al. (2020) Emergency healthcare needs in the Lavender Hill suburb of Cape Town, South Africa: a cross-sectional, community-based household survey. *BMJ Open* 10:e033643. doi:[10.1136/bmjopen-2019-033643](https://doi.org/10.1136/bmjopen-2019-033643)

Nunu WN, Munyewende PO. (2017) Patient satisfaction with nurse-delivery primary health care services in Free State and Gauteng provinces, South Africa: A comparative study. *Afr J Prm Health Care Fam Med*. 9(1):a1262. doi: [10.4102/phcfm.v9i1.1262](https://doi.org/10.4102/phcfm.v9i1.1262)

Owolabi EO, Goon DT, Ajayi AI, Adeniyi OV. (2022) Knowledge of diabetes and associated factors in rural Eastern Cape, South Africa: A cross sectional study. PLoS ONE 17(7): e0269811. doi: [10.1371/journal.pone.0269811](https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0269811)



Examine the methodology section of the survey documentation, and extract this information:

- 1) Which **population** the survey is interested to?
- 2) The aim/**research question(s)**
- 3) **Study design**
- 4) How the **sample** has been selected and recruited
- 5) How data have been **collected**



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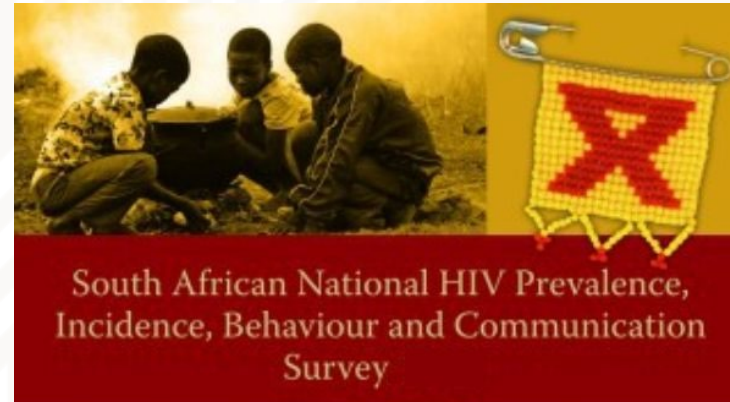
Other large scale surveys of interest for South Africa



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Statistics South Africa
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

General Household Survey



Summary questions

- What is a health survey?
- Study designs in health surveys
- Examples of health surveys: topics, methods, populations

References

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Other resources

- NDoH, StatsSA, SAMRC, ICF. 2019. *South Africa Demographic and Health Survey 2016: Report*. National Department of Health.
- Malukele, R. n.d. 'General Household Survey 2020: Measuring the Progress of Development in the Country'. Accessed 5 June 2022. <http://www.statssa.gov.za/publications/P0318/GHS%202020%20Presentation%202-Dec-21.pdf>.
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- NIDS Team. 2022. 'NIDS | South Africa Income Dynamics Study. 2022. <http://www.nids.uct.ac.za/>.
- Simbayi LC, Zuma K, Zungu N et al. South African National HIV Prevalence, Incidence, Behaviour and Communication Survey, 2017. <https://www.hsrcpress.ac.za/books/south-african-national-hiv-prevalence-incidence-behaviour-and-communication-survey-2017>



Thank you

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